# STELLA LINE LLC

MARITIME CONSULTING • SHIP & CARGO BROKERAGE • OCEAN TRANSPORTATION

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Issue No. 01 — Week of June 16, 2026 **CONFIDENTIAL — FOR ADDRESSEE USE ONLY**

To: Our Valued Customers & Partners
From: Stella Line LLC — Commercial & Market Intelligence Desk
Date: June 16, 2026

## RE: WEEKLY OCEAN FREIGHT MARKET UPDATE — GULF OF AMERICA & CARIBBEAN BASIN

Dear Customers and Partners,

We are pleased to share our weekly market intelligence update covering ocean freight conditions in the Gulf of America (formerly Gulf of Mexico), the Caribbean Basin, and key regional trade lanes relevant to your operations. This week's edition also includes a focused note on the Houston–Venezuela corridor, given recent inquiries from several of our clients.

As always, our goal is to keep you informed and commercially prepared. Please review the information below and contact us directly for any quotations, chartering discussions, or cargo brokerage opportunities.

## 1. GLOBAL OCEAN FREIGHT MARKET SNAPSHOT — WEEK OF JUNE 16, 2026

The global container market is in **active peak season mode**. Carriers implemented substantial General Rate Increases (GRIs) and Peak Season Surcharges (PSS) at the start of June, and those increases have held firm. Vessels on major lanes are **fully booked through the end of June**, with carriers rolling containers and reducing allocations on tighter lanes. The following key rate movements were recorded this week (source: Freightos Baltic Index, June 16, 2026):

| Trade Lane | Index | Weekly Change | Direction |
|---|---|---|---|
| Asia → US West Coast | FBX01 | Level / Flat | → Stable |
| Asia → US East Coast | FBX03 | **+4%** | **↑ Rising** |
| Asia → N. Europe | FBX11 | **+3%** | **↑ Rising** |
| Asia → Mediterranean | FBX13 | **-1%** | **↓ Minor dip** |
| Air: China → N. America | FAX | Level / Flat | → Stable |
| Air: China → N. Europe | FAX | **+3%** | **↑ Rising** |

**Key macro driver — US–Iran peace process:** A US–Iran interim peace deal was reportedly being finalized this week, including an agreement to begin reopening the Strait of Hormuz. While this has positive long-term implications for global fuel costs and routing, market consensus is that meaningful bunker relief remains **several months away** — too late to influence peak season 2026. De-mining of the Strait is expected to take weeks, and full crude flow normalization may take up to six months.

**Mid-month increases expected:** Carriers have announced additional mid-June GRIs of $1,000–$2,000/FEU on Asia–Europe lanes, with further increases of up to $2,000/FEU planned for July 1. CMA CGM has announced a

$4,000/FEU PSS for all transpacific containers starting July 10. As capacity is redirected to these high-demand corridors, **secondary lanes — including Gulf of America and Caribbean trades — are tightening as vessels are redeployed.**

## 2. GULF OF AMERICA & CARIBBEAN BASIN — MARKET CONDITIONS

The Gulf of America and Caribbean basin are experiencing **firm-to-tightening conditions** as we enter the summer peak. Port Everglades (Fort Lauderdale) — the #1 US port for Caribbean trade — continues to be the primary gateway, processing over 1.167 million TEUs in FY2025 and directing approximately 90% of its container volume to/from Latin America and the Caribbean.

**Kingston, Jamaica (KCT)**, the region's main transshipment hub, has seen gradual improvement after significant congestion bottlenecks in 2024–2025, though full normalization is still ongoing.

### Indicative FCL Rate Ranges — South Florida to Caribbean (June 2026):

| Destination | Main Port | 20ft (TEU) | 40ft (FEU) | Transit (Days) |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Bahamas | Nassau / Freeport | $1,000–$1,800 | $1,600–$2,600 | 2–4 |
| Haiti | Port-au-Prince | $1,500–$2,400 | $2,100–$3,400 | 4–7 |
| Dominican Republic | Haina / Rio Haina | $1,300–$2,200 | $1,900–$3,200 | 4–6 |
| Jamaica | Kingston | $1,500–$2,400 | $2,200–$3,600 | 5–8 |
| Trinidad & Tobago | Port of Spain | $2,000–$3,200 | $2,800–$4,400 | 9–14 |
| Colombia | Cartagena / Barranquilla | $1,800–$2,800 | $2,400–$4,000 | 7–12 |
| Panama | Colón / Balboa | $1,500–$2,300 | $2,100–$3,200 | 5–8 |
| Nicaragua | El Rama / Puerto Sandino | $1,700–$2,700 | $2,400–$3,800 | 6–10 |

Rates shown are indicative ocean freight (port-to-port). BAF, THC, documentation, and applicable surcharges are additional. See our complete rate reference guide for full detail.

### Break Bulk / LCL — per Revenue Ton (W/M Basis):

Break bulk and LCL cargo to the Caribbean is currently quoted at approximately **$60–$175 per Revenue Ton** depending on destination, cargo type, and port conditions. Revenue Ton = the higher of 1 metric ton (1,000 kg) or 1 cubic meter (CBM). Haiti and Venezuela attract the highest risk premiums in the region.

## 3. ROUTE FOCUS: HOUSTON → GUANTA, VENEZUELA

Several clients have inquired about the **Houston to Guanta, Venezuela** corridor. Here is a concise briefing on current conditions:

### Port of Guanta:

Located in Estado Anzoátegui on Venezuela's eastern coast, Guanta is a commercial port handling containers, bulk cargo, and petroleum-related products. Maersk confirms active service coverage at Guanta alongside Puerto Cabello, La Guaira, Maracaibo, and Guaranao.

### Indicative Freight — Houston to Guanta (June 2026):

| Service | Estimated Rate | Notes |
|---|---|---|
| 20ft Container (TEU) | $2,200–$3,600 | Peak season premium applied; includes Venezuela risk surcharge |
| 40ft Container (FEU) | $3,200–$5,200 | Subject to OFAC compliance clearance prior to booking confirmation |
| Break Bulk / LCL (per RT) | $130–$200/RT | Risk premium reflects sanctions environment and limited carrier options |
| Transit Time | 10–18 days | Often via transshipment (Curaçao or Kingston); direct sailings limited |

**■ IMPORTANT — U.S. SANCTIONS & COMPLIANCE NOTICE (VENEZUELA)**

Commercial shipping from the United States to Venezuela is subject to active U.S. Treasury OFAC (Office of Foreign Assets Control) sanctions. While cargo shipments are not categorically prohibited, they are subject to strict compliance requirements including: (1) screening of all parties (shipper, consignee, notify party, cargo) against the OFAC Specially Designated Nationals (SDN) list; (2) prohibition on shipments to or from entities owned or controlled by the Venezuelan government without a specific OFAC license; (3) restricted USD payment channels with Venezuelan counterparties; and (4) mandatory full booking details submitted at time of booking request — no blind bookings accepted by mainstream carriers. Stella Line LLC strongly recommends that all customers seeking to ship to Venezuela obtain independent legal counsel and OFAC compliance review before proceeding. Stella Line does not provide legal or sanctions compliance advice.

## 4. OUTLOOK & COMMERCIAL RECOMMENDATIONS

- **Book early — peak season pressure is real:** Capacity is tight and rates are rising on multiple lanes. Customers with shipments planned for July and August should secure space and rates as early as possible. Waiting for spot rates to drop before booking is a high-risk strategy in the current environment.
- **Lock in rates where possible:** If you have recurring cargo to Caribbean destinations, consider requesting a short-term contract rate (30–90 days) from your freight forwarder or directly from Stella Line. Spot rates are volatile and likely to continue rising through Q3 2026.
- **Monitor BAF and fuel surcharges closely:** The potential Strait of Hormuz reopening may eventually ease bunker costs, but this will be gradual. Do not assume fuel surcharges will drop soon — budget conservatively for Q3.
- **Venezuela cargo — prepare the compliance paperwork first:** Any shipment to Venezuela must have OFAC screening completed and carrier pre-approval before a booking can be confirmed. Do not quote or commit to customers before confirming carrier acceptance. Allow additional lead time of 3–5 business days for compliance processing.
- **Break bulk and project cargo windows:** For oversized or heavy-lift cargo to the Caribbean, pricing windows in June–early July may still offer reasonable rates before peak season fully materializes on smaller-vessel feeder trades. Contact Stella Line to discuss vessel options.

Stella Line LLC remains available to assist with cargo brokerage, vessel chartering inquiries, freight quotations, and market consulting for the Gulf of America, Caribbean, Mexico, Central America, and northern South America trades. Please contact us at **chartering@stella-line.com** or reach out directly to discuss your specific needs.

Warm regards,

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**Sources consulted for this issue:** Freightos Baltic Index Weekly Update (June 16, 2026); UNCTAD Review of Maritime Transport 2025; Maersk Rate Announcements; C.H. Robinson Ocean Market Updates; IndexBox Ocean Freight Rate Analysis (June 2026); J.M. Rodgers Freight Market Update (June 2026); U.S. Treasury OFAC Sanctions Guidance for Maritime Shipping. 